

Language, Madness and Politics:

A Theory of Plurality and Subversive Illegibility Through the Writing of Rita

Indiana, Francisco Matos Paoli and his Psychiatrists

By

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Introduction

I am writing this honors thesis as the culminating project to my independent concentration in Philosophical Inquiry Through Creative Forms. As part of the broader mission of my independent concentration, this project sets out to practice philosophy through an expanded conception of theoretical language, that goes beyond the analytical epistemic methods using reason and logic to argue for a privileged truth. For example, I believe that a field like *Biology* is not necessarily constrained to the logic of the scientific method, but rather it is open to the plurality of forms through which language (logos) allows us to question our experience of life (bios). There is no clear quantitative constrain on the linguistic “forms” we can use to generate theory and practice philosophy. We can always create new symbols and ways of communicating using these symbols if warranted. Hence the idea of “creative forms” as the cornerstone of innovation in philosophical inquiry necessary in the 21st century.

The plurality of linguistic forms that can be used to construct theory, necessarily implies a politics of symbolic systems and creative expression. There is a constant negotiation between grammar and experimentation, a struggle for harmonic coexistence in language so that legibility does not always dominate meaning. Allow me to illustrate what I mean. We grow up implicitly knowing the political nature of linguistic forms. Language acquisition is essentially a process by which a dominant sovereign figure, the parent, imposes a grammar on our creative expression in order to be socially legible by a linguistic community.

The mediation of grammar, those explicit or perhaps implicit linguistic rules, on our expression turns us into political beings by granting us access to said linguistic communities.

Politics is defined by both the actions one takes within a community, one's deeds, and speech, the narratives and stories of one's actions and other's activity. At the core of a political imaginary enacted by deeds and narrated by speech, is the possibility for "togetherness," or *living* together.¹ For Hannah Arendt, the act of thinking occupies an important place in political life as our ability to make value judgements and act accordingly in the world. It qualifies as a kind of deed formulated through speech, and therefore limited by the grammar of a given linguistic community.

For any political agent, thinking is informed by experience of the world, a world that (as Arendt describes in *The Human Condition*) is both natural and constructed by the human. This phenomenological experience is transformed, through thinking, into a "mode of subjectivity" (of the political agent) "specific to their system of meaning."² Not only this, but the fact that a world is in part constructed by agents operating under the system of meaning corresponding to that world, materially reinforces, or disrupts, the "mode of subjectivity" of the agent experiencing said world. In other words, the ability by which individuals judge experience and take action on the world, that is, thinking, has varying degrees of homogeneity and compatibility with the world being judged. The homogeneity can vary within a linguistic community due to the varying relationships between an agent in the community and its corresponding grammar. This relationship will vary with increasing degree for individuals outside of a linguistic community but inhabiting the "same"³ world, individuals part of the same linguistic community but

¹ Arendt (1998)

² Wynter (2001)

³ Since we have defined a feedback loop between the world and mode of subjectivity that experiences the world given their own grammar, "same" here is relative.

inhabiting different worlds, and even more so for individuals that are a part of a different linguistic community and inhabit a different world altogether.

The crass divisions between degrees of homogeneity in ways of thinking, combined with modes of subjectivity deeply intertwined with said thinking, can be put under the umbrella term Sylvia Wynter uses in *1492: A New World View* as different modes of subjective understanding, where understanding becomes the basis from where thinking can leap forth into action in the world. These are potential divisions representing different cultures and systems of belief. Any individual possesses a subjective understanding of reality which is constructed by unique experience and thinking in their respective worlds. A linguistic community is defined by a threshold degree of homogeneous subjective understanding across the members of the community. The world that said community inhabits and creates, can also house up to a certain degree of heterogeneous understanding beyond the threshold mentioned above. Within the threshold a member of the community is legible to its other members. Beyond the threshold, legibility decreases with increasing degrees of heterogeneous subjective understanding. Many distinct linguistic communities can inhabit a world,⁴ which can give rise to varying degrees of illegibility across different communities when we look at where these communities begin to intersect. Illegibility can be cultivated or spontaneously come about from within the legible strata of a community.

Linguistic experimentation and grammatical deviance are signs of illegibility in a community. Speech patterns, body language, looks, and actions, are all broadly construed into the conception of language I am working with. Deviations from the norm for any of these aspects

⁴ In this paper a world exists within the broader context of a planet, which following Gayatri Spivak's notion of "planetary."

of a language dictated by a grammar, tend to be assigned different labels: abnormal, weird, radical, strange, funny, interesting, creative, and crazy. I am interested in the grammatically deviant, and the potential for epistemological breakthroughs and political restructuring they entail. Just like different degrees of illegibility can be colloquially labeled by members of a linguistic community through varying optics, we have systems in place that can assign official labels based on scientific or medical standards. Because of science's claim to objectivity, labels assigned by the medical profession are often conflated with a true, static characterization of a patient's nature, rather than an interpretation of an externalization of someones inner life that is illegible to the community. This tension is crucial for my thesis.

I am concerned primarily with the topic and condition of madness. I suggest that madness is illegibility relative to a linguistic community, and its medical diagnosis as a mental illness is always a political act that reinforces the normalizing power of a communal language's grammar, which I will later refer to as the prescriptive form of language. There are many ways in which an individual labeled as "mad" can become illegible to their linguistic community. In the pages that follow I study the kind of illegibility that emerges from a "split mind," which etymologically is translated, and in a clinical setting might be diagnosed, as schizophrenia. The "split mind" I am interested in, and the illegibility it entails for a unified linguistic community, is reminiscent of Don Quixote: a literary portrayal of a person who has the ability to exist in juxtaposed worlds, that is, different realities that coexist with or without interference. Readers and writers are instances of this person. They "split" their mind by constructing imaginary worlds, which in turn shape their subjective understanding of the material world they inhabit as members of a linguistic community. This activity is "grammatical" as long as it is legible/consumable by the community

it is being produced in, and reinforces the mode of subjective understanding, or uses the same logic/grammar, to communicate lessons from the imaginary worlds.

The split mind of the writer refers to the split that occurs between their material reality and the imaginary reality they put into words. The material reality of the writer can be encoded into their imaginary in a cohesive manner, using the same codes that reign in their world to produce writing that is highly legible and does not contend the grammar of the community. But a writer can also inhabit their world from liminal positions, which offer a perspective that contends the cohesiveness of materiality and the political imaginary of a linguistic community.⁵ It is this kind of perspective, and the subsequent writing, that produces the kind of split mind that becomes illegible and is labeled as mad. It is also the state of mind that can disrupt and potentially change the dominant narratives of a community, and in so doing be the harbinger of political transformation. Wynter calls this kind of challenge to the dominant narratives and the symbolic rules governing a linguistic community a counter-symbolic move.⁶ This kind of movement is done from a liminal position, and can exist on its own without becoming mainstream and totally transform a political environment. What is the position of the writer in the development of the counter-symbolic? How is this labor embodied, and what are its effect on a writer's life, body and political agency when done genuinely.

Besides the investigation into the nature and political role of madness, this project also involves a biographical and, in a certain sense, biological investigation into the life stories of writers, a poet and a musician/novelist to be specific, working on counter-symbolic projects in

⁵ Wynter (2001)

⁶ Wynter (2007)

Puerto Rico and the Dominican Republic. By using a combination of published biographies, local history, and psychiatric records, I will reconstruct a bio-graphic recount of the life and labor of Caribbean writers working on changing politics from the side of the symbolic: the narratives that dominate the cultural discourses in the Caribbean colonies and ex-colonies. I am essentially investigating madness, its portrayal and embodiment by Caribbean poets, novelists and theorists.

On the first part of my thesis, I am focusing on Francisco Matos Paoli and his poem *Canto de la locura*. I use a combination of archival research on his personal psychiatric history and close readings of his poetry and diary. The second part of my thesis focuses on Rita Indiana and her novel *La mucama de Omicunlé*. I am making comparisons between her portrayal of madness in the novel and Matos Paoli's in his poem, especially in the different uses of language. I will also be writing on her song/video *El Flaco de La Mancha (En contra del abismo)*, where she directly engages with Matos Paoli by writing a song inspired by *Canto de la locura* and samples his voice reciting the poem.⁷ In the third and final part I dive into the conceptual differences between creative and prescriptive forms of language. I explore how Matos Paoli's psychiatric records define and shape madness through discursive and pharmacological prescriptions. Throughout the work I will be using theorists such as Sylvia Wynter and Hannah Arendt to guide me through the terminology and concepts needed to build a philosophical framework where madness becomes a crucial player for transformative politics in the Caribbean. My goal is to show how Matos Paoli and Rita Indiana complement each other's narratives concerning madness and ultimately offer insight on the creative forms and psychological/biological risks of political action needed for colonial emancipation.

⁷ Indiana Hernández (2020)

Ch. 1: Canto de la locura

Francisco Matos Paoli's Theory and Experience of Madness as the Overturn of Colonial Reason

In 1950 a nationalist revolt was attempted to declare Puerto Rican independence. Throughout the island, members of the Puerto Rican Nationalist party and its sympathizers attempted to take several of the island's towns by force. In Jayuya, they succeeded in taking the police headquarters, and declared Puerto Rico a free republic in the town square. The uprising was met with the full force of the U.S. Army. Jayuya was bombed and under heavy machine gun fire, forcing them to surrender. This response set-off a sequence of adverse reactions by upset Nationalists living in the diaspora, like the assassination attempt of president Truman, and the attack on the U.S. House of Representatives. Besides the reactions on the part of the Nationalist party, the violent suppression of the revolt continued in the form of mass incarceration of the political and intellectual leaders of the independence movement. Alongside the president of the Nationalist party, Pedro Albizu Campos, the proclaimed national poet Francisco Matos Paoli was sentenced to 10 years of imprisonment for his role as general secretary of the Nationalist Party. He was legally arrested for having a Puerto Rican flag in his study, which was illegal under the Gag Law (ley de la Mordaza or ley 53 del 1948). Although Matos Paoli saw his arrest as an act of martyrdom, the experience had a huge toll on his mental health. In the first 18 months of his detainment in "La Princesa" Matos Paoli developed the symptoms for what was then diagnosed as paranoid schizophrenia. Matos Paoli spent the next years of his sentence between psychiatric

hospitals, prisons and probation. In 1955 he received an official pardon, but he would continue dealing with the effects detainment had on his mental health for the rest of his life.⁸

In prison, Matos Paoli covered the walls and ceiling of his cell with poems. He wrote two of his most important poems, *Luz de los héroes* (1951) and *Canto Nacional a Borinquen* (1955) during his detainment. Perhaps his most famous poem, *Canto de la Locura*, was written in 1961, around 10 years after his initial incarceration and diagnosis. In this long free-verse poem (989 verses), Matos Paoli reflects on his experience of madness as both a clinical diagnosis that attempts to strip him from political agency and an anti-colonial emancipatory epistemology.⁹ In his diary, Matos Paoli accounts for how his experience with schizophrenia has removed him from an explicitly active role in the fight for Puerto Rican independence. He wonders if he will be forgiven by his compatriots when they see him inactive in the national political arena.¹⁰ Removed from active political organizing, he focused on the effect his newfound condition had on himself, and the lessons to be learned from it. He says in his diary that his experience with madness helped ground him, allowing him to see into the immanence of things rather than transcending them. In his psychiatric records he talks about a new-found humility and being open to learn from anyone around him. His psychiatrist explains that he began seriously self-studying psychology and engaged voluntarily with mystic fits he recounted as meaningful truth-revealing experiences. It is evident in his records that he is quite conscious of his condition, and is actively engaging with it to learn from it as he rethinks his role in Puerto Rico's emancipatory politics.

⁸ Matos Paoli (1953-2000)

⁹ Zambrano Murillo (2017)

¹⁰ Matos Paoli (2011)

In *Canto de la Locura* he writes:

Yo quiero conocerme:
abandonar la ignota multiplicación de los astros,
la abundancia tranquila
en que el amor es loto.¹¹

From these lines we can see the poetic image Matos Paoli develops in dialogue with his diary entries and his psychiatrist's notes. His madness, now intertwined with his calling as a poet, drive him to desire a deeper understanding of himself, abandoning his past intellectually airy disposition to discover his inner abundance where the possibility of love is encapsulated. This is an important calling not only for himself as a madman, but to his reader. Although he does claim a degree of asceticism after his experience with schizophrenia, Matos Paoli by no means abandons the nationalist party's political project even if his new condition forces him to revise the kinds of paths that can be taken to reach their goal.

In his diary, he has an important section where he investigates his use of the first person in his poetry, specifically in *Canto de la Locura*. He talks of the poetic "I" as a singularity that holds within it a plurality of subjects when used in a poetic setting. He is conscious that each time he uses "I" in his poems, he not only refers to himself, but to a collective "other" where the reader might be implicated. In the poem he writes:

Yo, aunque demente,
no me cojo miedo en la insolidaria alondra,
me atrapo en el diáfano estertor de la tiniebla,

¹¹ Matos Paoli (2016), pp 14.

me fecundo a mí mismo

al saber que soy el otro rodeado de centellas.¹²

There is an explicit treatment of the poetic “I” that becomes “other.” In doing this, Matos Paoli gives voice to the poem itself, and the verses begin speaking about their own plural existence in the minds of readers. In declaring himself insane, he is also declaring the other insane, and in the following pages he stops using the first person singular to explicitly reveal a collective, captured by the poem’s readers, who must go mad with him:

Tenemos que enloquecer

extraer de nosotros mismos la raíz despavorida del cielo

volcar nuestras miradas fatigantes,

quedar solos con una extraña soledad acompañada¹³

In this excerpt he is calling for a collective maddening of his readership, presumably Puerto Ricans that could supersede colonial rule by extracting that terrified root from themselves and ending in a new found independence, what he refers to as a “strange accompanied solitude.” At the same time he is giving us insight into the inner mechanisms of his poem: how the words on the page itself are already splitting our minds, and leaving us in a “strange accompanied solitude” between our corporeal and abstracted reader selves. In these verses he identifies a role for madness in superseding subjugation. For this sake he proposes his poem, or perhaps poetry in general, as a method to approach madness and discover epistemological alternatives that support emancipatory politics.

¹² Ibid., pp 20.

¹³ Ibid., pp 29.

In the eyes of the politicians in power at the time, the Nationalists were crazed radicals that were dangerous for the common people. Many of the diagnosis of insanity that were done for the leaders of the party, which included Albizu Campos besides Matos Paoli, provided medical and scientific backing for the neocolonial political order of Luis Muñoz Marín. In a sense, these diagnoses helped solidify the political credibility of the government that suppressed Puerto Rican nationalism and independence sentiment in the 50s. Although Matos Paoli's condition subsumed him to a less active role in the nationalist project, he flipped the discourse that had been used to politically disempower him and his fellow nationalists as mad folk by saying madness was a catalyst for freedom.

Besides his use of poetry to reflect on his experience with madness, *Canto de la Locura* is also filled with religious (Catholic) references that he uses to develop the symbolic system that his poem operates through. Christian symbols have been used in the Caribbean for symbolic subversion many times in the past. In Sylvia Wynter's work, Rastafarianism is portrayed as an exemplary instance of this phenomenon. The Rastafarian religion, born from a tradition of black radical nationalism in Jamaica cultivated by Marcus Garvey, was seen by the governing class as a group of madmen. In a similar way to how Matos Paoli uses Christian references to construct the retelling of the experience of madness and his radical calling to collective madness, Rastafarians used biblical references to construct a new symbolic system from where to draw radically different beliefs, values and politics. Wynter re-articulates Rastafarian's "madness" as a counter-symbolic move against the colonial and anti-African sentiment of the Jamaican ruling class.¹⁴

¹⁴ Wynter (2007)

Is this the kind of collective “maddening” that Matos Paoli is calling for? Although it doesn’t seem like his anti-colonial sentiment is tied to afro-cultural repression in Puerto Rico like it was for Rastafarianism in Jamaica, I believe his call to madness is signaling for an overhaul of the symbolic systems under which Puerto Ricans are oppressed colonial subjects. He believes that his experience with madness has allowed him to see what exists beyond the confines of colonial reason, or the kind of subjective understanding that dominates the colonial subject’s mind. True emancipation from U.S. colonial rule is only possible when there is a polis/city/nation of Puerto Ricans gone mad.

How does such a city look like? Is politics even possible in a city of people gone mad? For such a city to exist, our conception of politics would have to be expanded beyond the associations that come to mind when the word is mentioned: political parties, congress, policy, lobbying and international relations, to mention a few. I suggest here thinking with Hannah Arendt about politics as essentially forging “togetherness.”¹⁵ In other words, creating and implementing practices and collective narratives that facilitate living together. As an example, for the Rastafarians this meant living in their own communities removed from the towns and making a living on their own terms. Their narrative was one of exile from the land where they belonged, Africa, which made use of the Bible’s story of exodus. The counter-symbolic move made by the Rastafarians in Jamaica allowed for the formation of a new kind of community and therefore novel politics.

Matos Paoli attempts a counter-symbolic move with his poetry, where Christian symbolism also plays a big role. But although he assumes the existence of a collective in the

¹⁵ Arendt (1998)

reader, I believe that practically speaking, he is not writing for the community he targets. In his treaties on the art of poetry, he talks about the important balance between comprehensibility and incomprehensibility in writing poetry. There is a balance that is struck between expressing a certain interiority that flows out of the writer, and making that expression sensible to the reader, grounding it enough on common reality and language for it to be legible.

Matos Paoli oscillates in his writing between periods of lucidness and obscurity according to his poetic ethics. In doing so, he develops a way of understanding madness through the poetic medium. This epistemological experiment is arguably necessary for the political project underlying his poem. Although he is successful in developing a “poetic” epistemology of madness, he is not as successful in bringing to fruition the collective maddening he is calling forth, not because it is not enticing, but because it is implemented using a language that is not grounded in a vocabulary accessible to most people in the linguistic community he is targeting. Therefore the set of symbols that he is overturning go unperceived by the reader that does not share his specific symbolic literacy and scholastic background. I believe the novel *La Mucama de Omicunlé* and the song “El Flaco de La Mancha” by Rita Indiana, serve as a counter-example to Matos Paoli’s inaccessible language while still pursuing his political project. In the next chapter we will see how she uses a more familiar sounding language as she delves deep into the topic of madness in her texts.

Concerning the epistemology of madness Matos Paoli brings to the table in his poem and diary entries, he suggests that in his experience with madness he has been able to witness what lies beyond the realm of reason, thus freeing him from its confines and revealing to him different possibilities for reality. His psychiatric record recounts that these “alternate” realities were not

always compatible with the common consensus view of how reality operates. When challenged by views inconsistent with his alternate realities, he could sometimes become aware of his split existence causing him to get frustrated. He was able to generate new beliefs that existed beyond the confines of what is deemed reasonable by his linguistic community, but they were subjected to analysis under the grammar he himself knew to apply to reality, which caused mental strife.

This said, he was able to experiment with these experiences and develop a “poetic epistemology” of his madness by testing the limits of what is reasonable. In *Canto de la Locura* he give the reader insight into this process:

Después de la sutil locura
se agranda mi dios en los lirios,
empiezo a darme luz en las esquinas
y se paraliza el polen de los muertos
en lo que de mí está sellado.¹⁶

His madness comes in episodes. As the psychiatric records confirm, Matos Paoli had periods of euphoria and periods of profound fear, sadness and disenchantment, which could appear out of the blue, perhaps triggered by some event, or built-up through time. It is not much surprise that his diagnosis was later changed from schizophrenia to bipolar disorder after the prolonged monitoring of his symptoms. In this excerpt he describes what happens “after the subtle madness.” We can potentially interpret these verses as the aftermath of an episode, or rather, the time after the instantaneous transition into a mental state that can only be called madness for a split second. At the point of transition, he is able to detect what truths hid from him before then.

¹⁶ Matos Paoli (2016), pp 18.

His use of death here serves as a symbol for his knowledge of the world. In the initial days of his madness, Matos Paoli believed that people did not die. He eventually abandoned the belief and developed a great fear of death which was noted by his doctors. In his poetic re-signification, he is able to portray the tension that exists between the revealing nature of his madness and the terrifying siren song of the “sane” and “grammatical” reality.

me llaman.

Que hacer si los brazos ahuecados

aún repiten el aroma?¹⁷ (18)

He poses the question of what to do when the contradictions arise: death is paralyzed, but his arms still exude death’s odor. These kinds of contradictions become the limit where madness exists, beyond them lies a different reality, a different kind of knowledge where death is not the end of life, and perhaps true colonial emancipation is possible.

La ignición del sueño

comienza a crecer.¹⁸

The double meaning of ignition as both start and combustion reveal the dream of madness to be a dream among dreams, one that begins after the subtle state of madness as it combusts the previous dream of “normal” reality.

El límite deja,

como la serpiente,

su radiosa piel.¹⁹

¹⁷ Ibid., pp 18.

¹⁸ Ibid., pp 19.

¹⁹ Ibid., pp 19.

The imagery of a serpent molting its skin serves as a metaphor for the change of realities in the aftermath of madness. The limit of the maddening contradiction is left behind like the molted skin of the serpent for a new logic with a transformed counter-symbolic system of meaning. The poem itself becomes a guide through the epistemological break with reality and the exploration of alternative epistemologies that liberate the reader from an oppressive grammar through poetic language.

In his poem, Matos Paoli narrates his madness as he experienced it. The poem can be read as intellectual and spiritual: as a series of disembodied events narrating an intimate experience of madness. However, the poem can also be read as an account of the embodiment of madness. Just like I have argued that the poem can be seen as a guide through an epistemological break through madness, I believe that the structure, the rhythm and the symbolic relationships being conveyed by the poem point towards a way in which the body processes madness. In other words, Matos Paoli is not only developing a way of knowing reality that lies outside of reason, but is demonstrating how this epistemology is tied to the embodiment of “un-grammatical” knowledge conveyed by the affect the poem produces on the reader.

The poem itself reflects the real life experience of Matos Paoli since 1953 when he was diagnosed with schizophrenia. The fact that he uses free verse helps convey the fluidity of his condition. In his records his life as a madman can be read in a similar way to how his poem is read. There is a certain unpredictability in the betterment and worsening of his condition, there are motifs that get repeated, like a paralyzing fear of death, or the cleaning of his home’s stairs as an act of humility, that ground a sense of reality that is constantly challenging the cohesiveness of the collective mode of subjective understanding that surrounds him.

This is analogous to the structure of the poem. Repeating symbolic and linguistic motifs, like the theme of death, Christianity, madness, and natural imagery, create a path for the reader in a forest of verses that does not have the need to sustain a cohesive meaning throughout the poem. The verses are almost memoryless, making it hard to pinpoint the proper interpretation of the narrative being constructed from page to page. They are not fully memoryless because they repeat words, tropes and symbolic motifs that create associations across the pages. In doing this Matos Paoli makes evident the delicate construction of meaning in a poem where it is being taken to its limits before our very eyes. He produces a delicate transparent web that gives us insight into the fragility of the unquestioned meaning we assign to reality on a daily basis.

This is precisely the condition of madness which he is experiencing in his own body, and which allows him to construct such a delicate poem that illustrates the fragile phenomenon of making meaning out of reality. In general, this is a necessary condition in poetry, where the construction of metaphors through the manipulation of pre-existing symbols can potentially produce new meaning.²⁰ Experiencing madness, this condition gets embodied and reality itself becomes a fragile blank page where anything can be written and have meaning because the mind's pre-existing grammar has been broken down. In this state of mind, where a patient might be diagnosed as mad and a poet might write poetry, the grammar that rules over the symbolic structures we use to communicate becomes less rigid. Depending on how consumed one is by this mental state, it can lead to the creation of the counter-symbolic system of meaning that Wynter deems necessary for radical societal change.

²⁰ Arendt (1977)

The counter-symbolic move emerges from the space that Matos Paoli identifies “after madness,” when the limit (of reason) is left behind like the molted skin of a serpent. This is, as well, the space where poetry is made and where we can “cross from the minor truth of the seen to the major truth of the unseen” by means of the creation of metaphors that bridge the symbolic structures we know, to the counter-symbolic structures we need to create.²¹ In doing so, poetry creates a way to transition from different narratives concerning reality by embodying a kind of madness, even if it is only for an instant, after reading or while writing, but before fully interpreting a poem.

The psychological state necessary for this kind of work is precarious.²² A poet inhabits this precarious state of mind by the nature of their craft, not constantly, but very often. I am really talking about a class of mental states rather than a single universal mental state that all poets inhabit when writing poetry. For Matos Paoli, his version of the poet’s psychological state was defined by a transcendentalism that separated him from people, and put him soaring in high intellectual and spiritual grounds. He admits in both his psychiatric records and diary that this was his demeanor before being incarcerated and experiencing madness. The mental precariousness that comes with handling metaphors to forge poems gives poets a worldly sensibility that does not just experience the world, but transforms and translates it into a set of symbolic representations that multiply their own meaning rather than fix a single meaning to them. This is the work that goes into forging metaphors, which arguably predisposes the poets to what many consider madness given the right circumstances.

²¹ Ibid., pp 106.

²² When I talk of a mental or psychological state I am thinking of the mind as a bodily entity, grounded in the entire body as is becoming increasingly evident through modern neuroscience.

The process of making poetry depends wholly on the bodily experience of the poet. The transformation of experience into its multiplicity of meanings is not purely an intellectual process, but rather one that depends deeply on the multiple sensorial modalities that cover our body. The multiplicity of sensation that allows us to experience reality in many ways is the key to poetic production, and if this bodily sensibility is co-opted, there are consequences to the ability of even creating non-poetic meaning out of reality. The incarceration to which Matos Paoli was subjected disrupted the transcendental psychological environment where he worked on his poetry. The delicate work of a national poet entrusted with producing the symbolic language of liberation that would displace colonial narratives in Puerto Rico, was suddenly confronted with absolute confinement. The narrative of liberation Matos Paoli had been embodying since he joined and actively participated in the nationalist party was suddenly subjected to imprisonment. Although he was at first proud to be sacrificing his individual freedom for the cause of Puerto Rican independence, he was later shocked by his confinement, and his poetic-physiological environment was materially coopted: the transcendental image of freedom for the island was not sustainable from the material confinement of a prison cell.

In his diary, Matos Paoli mentions the shift in perspectives of his poetic sensibilities and political engagement during his imprisonment. In his psychiatric records he tells his doctor that he is actually grateful for the experience of incarceration because he learned more there than in his entire time at the university, although it is not clear whether this was a sustained belief throughout the years.²³ He was undoubtedly traumatized by the experience, and given the kinds of psychiatric treatments used at the time, the toll on his mental and bodily well-being was

²³ Matos Paoli (1953-2000)

immense, not to mention the amount of physical and emotional labor that his family had to do, especially his wife, to take care of him. That said, he is able to recognize that going mad opened up the doors to a realm of thinking beyond the logic he had been operating under throughout his life, even as a radical political figure for Puerto Rican independence. It is in this space of new possible logics which he inhabits from time to time, that a real political revolution can happen in Puerto Rico. Although this space exists and it is reachable, as shown in *Canto de la Locura*, the way of getting there is not necessarily through such terrible bodily trauma, but rather through a conscious practice of poetic creation constantly pushing at the limits of reason, as Matos Paoli illustrates in his poem and through his life.

Ch. 2: La mucama de Omicunlé

The Language of Becoming Mad Portrayed by Rita Indiana's Fictional Writing and Music

Unlike the poem, the modern novel is considered a popular medium for the consumption of creative writing. The kind of poetry Matos Paoli was writing in the 1950's was in part inspired by the poetry of Paul Valéry, and therefore the symbolist movement from late 19th-century France. Matos Paoli writes in his journal about his admiration for Valéry's poetry and, particularly in *Canto de la Locura*, he tends towards the use of his mystical visions and symbolism to uncover general truths about madness, political struggle, and freedom. The highly symbolic language in his poetry is not necessarily the most accessible for a popular audience. Many of the references in the system of symbols Matos Paoli creates throughout *Canto de la Locura* can be lost to a general audience who is unfamiliar with these and the vocabulary associated. In contrast, Rita Indiana's novel, *La mucama de Omicunlé*, is written how we speak. Although the Spanish used might be inaccessible to someone outside Dominican Republic and Puerto Rico, there is a match between the political intervention of the novel and its main intended audience due to how language is being used. This is not to say that the novel is not linguistically rich and sophisticated, on the contrary, the flexibility with which Indiana chooses to treat the novel's language proves to push language to its limits and reveal its role in madness.

Rita Indiana is a Dominican fiction writer and a singer song-writer of Dominican origins now living in Puerto Rico. A lot of her work is inspired by her personal experiences growing up in the Dominican Republic, which she mixes with historical narratives (both popular and speculative) and a unique combination of science fiction and mythical fantasy. In the novel *La*

mucama de Omicunlé, all these aspects come together in what she herself has proclaimed, and I undoubtedly agree, to be her masterpiece. The relatively short novel follows the parallel stories of Acilde and Argenis, two Dominicans who live between the echelons of society at two different periods: 2027 and 2010 respectively. Acilde works as a house servant or “mucama” for Esther Escudero, an important “santera” in the Afro-Caribbean religion of Santería common to the mayor Antilles. In 2027, the Caribbean had been recently devastated by a tsunami that destroyed a state-owned arsenal of biological weapons and spread its toxic contents across the Caribbean Sea and Atlantic Ocean. This killed most of the sea life that proliferated across the archipelago and sustained tourism as a major source of income for many of the islands. The story of Acilde unfolds within this eco-political context. Her character is driven to do sexual odd-jobs where she poses as a young boy for pedophilic rich and powerful men in order to save up money to purchase a drug called the “Rainbow Bright.” This drug induces a full sex-change with no surgical intervention. She reaches Esther through one of her clients, Eric Vitier, who as Esther’s friend recommends her for the service job after paying for her services. The new job leaves her in a much more comfortable position to reach her goal. This comprises the opening scenes of the novel. The choice to situate the plot in a not-so-distant post-apocalyptic future gives the present day reader a strange sense of familiarity that is disturbed with every new quotidian description of the futuristic reality where data plans are integrated into people’s body and machines are used to identify and eliminate illegal Haitian immigrants carrying a deadly virus.

As the plot develops and thickens, the sense of familiarity is further disturbed and distorted in violent ways. Colloquial descriptors are used to describe familiar environments like the pier and the boardwalk in their new post-apocalyptic configuration. The normalization of devastation that occurs during the first couple of chapters gives off a feeling of uncanniness that is later taken

to an extreme. The way Indiana uses colloquial Dominican Spanish makes the Caribbean reader recognize the post-apocalyptic Dominican Republic dystopia as something very close to home. The non-Caribbean reader has to abstract her use of language to echo a similar relationship between a familiar home defined by local linguistic practices and the devastated Dominican Republic. This way Indiana grounds her reader in an uncanny world that eventually, quite suddenly and explosively, takes a turn into hard sci-fi fantasy without ever letting go of its familiar grounding.

Indiana grapples with themes of social and economic disparity, governmental corruption, environmental ruin, gender and sexuality, ethnic and religious divides, and personal and systemic violence. She weaves these highly intertwined issues across the entire narrative through the lens of a unique combination of Caribbean inspired sci-fi fantasy. When Acilde is offered a quick way of gaining the remaining money to buy the Rainbow Bright by her friend Morla, she eventually succumbs to the temptation of stealing from Esther. In a special high-tech vase that regulates the water purity and nutrients inside it, there is a priceless anemone that Acilde steals to sell through the black market. Due to the recent catastrophic events where sea life was wiped out from the Caribbean, sea creatures are illegally very sought after by wealthy “collectors.” Acilde succeeds in the theft, but after things go south and both Esther and Morla violently meet their end, Acilde goes on the lam with the anemone after wrongfully being accused for homicide. After a series of unfortunate events with an anarchist Christian sect, she eventually makes a deal with Eric, who trades the Rainbow Bright for the anemone. Eric, who is a doctor, agrees to administer the drug which requires professional assistance. Before the transformation, Acilde gets strapped down to a table to immobilize her during the extremely painful procedure. At this point, we get introduced to the fantastical dimension of the story. Unbeknownst to Acilde, everything that has happened

and will happen: the eco-catastrophe, Esther's death, and her incoming transformation, are all part of an old prophecy where she, and in a few moments he, is the chosen son of Olokún, one of the major deities in Santería that represents the depths of the ocean. Once transformed, he is meant to travel back in time to prevent the ecological disaster from ever happening. By interfacing with the sea anemone, he is able to grow a doppelgänger body in the past from another anemone there and fulfill his destiny.

The introduction of Santería mythology into the fore of the novel's narrative as part of the fictional reality being constructed gives a fantastical spin to the so far science-fiction story, but it reproduces the same logic Indiana has been operating through in terms of her use of language. The use of local religion to construct the mythology of the plot acts in a similar way to the use of local language to describe the fictional reality. Suddenly, the spiritual forces operating in the background of the novel's world are guided by a familiar force to a local practicing Santería. Like in the case of the language, a reader uninitiated in the practices of Santería can still recognize how its local cosmology creates a space that is grounded in a familiar logic tied to the location where the story is unfolding. This is even more the case for Caribbean Spanish speakers who's colloquial language is being used to introduce the Santería cosmology as part of the novel's reality.

I want to draw attention to this consistent use of language and Caribbean cultural practices used by Rita Indiana in order to contrast it with Francisco Matos Paoli's own use of language and his Caribbean context. While Indiana is primarily drawing from colloquial Spanish and local religion, Matos Paoli draws his language from an erudite Spanish and mystical Catholicism that he developed through his consistent interaction with academia and the Catholic Church. Although both writers have a compatible understanding of madness (as we will see in the pages

that follows), I think their methodologies of presenting their knowledge is distinct. That is of course, with the exception of both using the Spanish language. The primary differentiation between the two is in terms of the accessibility to their content through the kind of Spanish they implement in their writing, also constrained by literary form (novel vs. poem). Secondly and related, there is the degree of indigeneity associated with the references to religious cosmologies.

Rita Indiana exposes through her writing the politics that exists within the Spanish language. Like Arendt writes in her thinking diary (*Denktagbuch*), it is crucial that there is a plurality of languages that don't only differ in vocabulary, but also in grammar.²⁴ The colloquial words and phrasing that Indiana uses throughout her novel reveals a plurality of Spanish, which centers the socio-cultural and political environment of the Caribbean. There is a socio-political separation between Spanish spoken and written Spanish in the Caribbean, this is the case with any language, but specially in the Caribbean it points towards a history of how intellectual and literary production has been defined by divisions of socio-economic class. Literature was traditionally produced by individuals that could afford schooling from a young age and become "literate," which for the most part fell under the Antillean bourgeois. Poets like Luis Pales Matos from Puerto Rico, began introducing Afro-Caribbean vocabulary into mainstream poetry as early as 1926. Although there is a tradition of merging vocabularies across socio-economic divides in Caribbean Spanish in literature, it was by no means a standard practice by the 1950's. Matos Paoli tends to use a much more erudite Spanish for his poetry. Although he was, for a time, thought of as the national poet by the nationalist party, his use of language was not accessible to the vast majority of the "nation," at least in its past contemporary configuration.

²⁴ Arendt (2017) pp. 42

Rita Indiana mainly works with the kind of Spanish that is spoken in Dominican Republic and Puerto Rico. Although she is a reader of Matos Paoli's poetry, which is evident by her direct reference to *Canto de la Locura* in her recent song "El Flaco de La Mancha," she chooses to write using a language that is not only accessible to most of the "nation," but also familiar. This does not mean that her prose is always easy to read, or that it has the kind of dry descriptive language from naturalist literature to which authors belonging to the symbolist movement were reacting. Indiana plays a lot with language. Perhaps because she is first a musician, the entirety of her novel has a certain rhythm to it. The plot of the novel can become quite convoluted at times given the kinds of fantastical situations the characters eventually find themselves in, and in these cases the language itself reflects the complexity of the situations by becoming strained itself. Perhaps we can call these moments where language gets strained when trying to capture the fictional reality of the characters in the novel, a different kind of inaccessibility. In contrast with Matos Paoli's poem, this kind of inaccessibility is dramatized in the writing itself, the strain in the language is a strain on the fictional character's psyche as well. Because their experiences can suddenly go beyond speech, the inaccessibility of the linguistic experiments Indiana performs in her novels match the state of the characters in the novel. In the end, because the novel's form and the way it interacts with the reader, the way Indiana plays with language ends up being intuitively accessible to the reader given the sympathetic relationship readers develop through the plot with the characters.

The plurality of Spanish that is revealed when comparing Matos Paoli's poem with Indiana's novel reflects the different degrees of indigeneity between the two texts. Sylvia Wynter develops the term indigenization as a way of understanding the process by which African slaves taken to the Caribbean islands culturally melded with the Arawakan, or specifically Taíno, natives to

eventually become indigenous people to the Caribbean. In *La mucama de Omicunlé*, Rita Indiana portrays the end product of this process of indigenization fantastically. The depths of both the Taíno and the African roots in the Dominican Republic are captured by the centrality of the Santería religion and its Afro-Caribbean cosmology, and by characters who are impacted by or whose existence is indicative of these deep roots. For example, there is a Taíno family that is in charge of taking care of the time-traveling anemones and fulfilling Acilde's prophecy. They allude to the shadowy but essential presence of the Taíno in the island, and their deep ties with the local environment. Meanwhile the presence of African culture is separately depicted in one of the "origin stories" of a character later introduced in the novel. A young girl interested in DJing encounters a group of Haitian workers who, after a day of hard labor in the fields, get together to play drums and dance with a rhythm and intensity she would never forget and shape her music career. In the novel, the African roots are as grounded in the land as the Taíno, and through the Santería cosmology that pervades the entire novel, these two legacies are cooperatively intertwined to accomplish the goal of rescuing the Caribbean environment.

One of the other prominent sites where the product of indigenization is prevalent in Indiana's novel is the language it is written in. Many of the colloquial words in Dominican Spanish have Taíno or African origins. In contrast, Matos Paoli's poem is written in an erudite Spanish with little to no evidence of other linguistic roots and cosmologies that are not Spanish and Catholic. It is arguably important to point out that it is a Puerto Rican who has managed mastery over an erudite Spanish. In the 1950's this could have been seen as a kind of de-colonial move since Spanish had become, through the US military occupation of Puerto Rico, the colonized language. Mastery over Spanish and eloquently writing for Puerto Rican independence had revolutionary airs, but also carried with it remnants of the previous colonial order under

Spanish rule. Rita Indiana goes deeper into the de-colonial potential of the linguistic medium. In a similar way that the African and Taíno traditions meld together in the novel to save the Caribbean environment from catastrophe, they also meld together in Spanish in order to appropriate the colonial language and make it the familiar tongue through which Caribbean readers speak. The resistance that is indigenous to the Caribbean is actively speaking to the reader. By reading, and therefore embodying this voice, the reader is compelled to the kind of emancipatory politics Matos Paoli is invested in by the mere form of the language being used and its cohesiveness with the content: ecological care in the Caribbean coasts.

The language in *La mucama de Omicunlé* vs. *Canto de la locura* have different ties to Caribbean indigeneity and therefore different political functions when read by a Caribbean audience. These two texts expose how language and its relationship with madness generate political interventions. Each use a kind of language with distinct political implications due to their relationship with the process of indigenization in the Caribbean. The different portrayals of madness in these texts, give us distinct yet related ideas, concepts and perhaps theories of how madness relates to politics, and how language relates to madness. In the pages to come, I will focus on how Rita Indiana chooses to depict madness in her novel through another story within the same novel following a different character that is initially completely unrelated to Acilde's story. Through this narrative, and its eventual merger with Acilde's mythical destiny, Indiana gives us a different perspective on the politics of madness and how she wields language as a medium that accomplishes Matos Paoli's poetic interjection:

Tenemos que enloquecer.²⁵

²⁵ Matos Paoli, pp 29.

A second parallel story unfolds in the recent past following the character of Argenis. He is a painter who is chosen to participate in an artist residency program ran by Giorgio Menicucci, a local business man who we later discover is Acilde's doppelgänger. Argenis somewhat fits the trope of the tortured artist. He is extremely talented but arrogant, obsessively critical of his fellow artists in residency and a blatant misogynist. Going after Lisa, Giorgio's wife, in a group scuba diving excursion, he accidentally comes into contact with the special sea anemone that allowed Acilde to travel back in time. This accidental encounter makes Argenis unknowingly travel back to 17th century Dominican Republic and join an eclectic group of pirates while simultaneously inhabiting his body in the late 20th century. This mental-corporeal delocalization begins to give Argenis trouble. He has little control over when he is present vs. in the past, and sometimes the two realities meld together to produce the symptoms of a schizophrenic-like disorder.

Rita Indiana constructs the different narratives of the novel in such a way that the reader experiences the disjuncture of Argenis' reality alongside him. She transitions from narrating events happening in the present to the remote past without any announcement. The words on the page have periods where they stop referencing something particular within one of the given narrative, whether in the past or the present. At these ambivalent intervals within a chapter, a page, or a sentence, the words suddenly gain a semantic plurality, which negates their ability to latch onto any one solid meaning or referent. By reading further, there is an ongoing process of induction which eventually places the reader in one of the two time points. Once temporally located, one can continue reading guided by the internal logic of the identified narrative. The ambivalent transitions between realities and the linguistic disruption they cause in the

narratological flow of the novel simulate the psychic phenomenon that both Rita Indiana and Francisco Matos Paoli are exploring through their writing, which I identify as madness.

Although the words on the page are always part of the set combinations of symbols allowed by the Spanish language, the way in which these words are combined throughout the novel will either signify events occurring in world 1 (20th century Dominical Republic) or world 2 (17th century Dominical Republic), at least in the case of Argenis' story arc. There are prescriptive ways in which transitions between times, spaces, realities, etc. can take place within a novel. One example in *La mucama de Omicunlé*, is the way in which Rita Indiana transitions from Argenis' story to Acilde's story by ending a chapter and beginning a new one. There is also the case of Acilde's time traveling, which is much more controlled and intentional. In many cases the transitions between Acilde's 21st century reality and world 1 (where he is Giorgio), happen within solitary confinement in a prison cell when Acilde goes to sleep. The time traveling capacities of the anemones fit into the narrative of Acilde's reality and the general cosmology of the novel without the disruption it causes in Argenis' story. Transitions are made by either simple description or implicit through the space between chapters.

It is worth noting that part of the way in which Argenis' and Acilde's time traveling is different is that Acilde's occurs during the time he is locked up by the Dominican authorities right after his transformation. The president of the Dominican republic, Said Bona, is actually aware of Acilde's mission due to his connections with Esther who served as his religious adviser. Acilde is given a comfortable prison cell in solitary confinement to minimize external distraction and facilitate the accomplishment of his mission. It is ironic that the prison cell becomes the safest place to transition between realities, and eventually, at the end of the novel, for Acilde to escape the apocalyptic reality of the 21st century Dominical Republic by killing his imprisoned

body living in that time. There is a rich parallel between Matos Paoli's life experiences and Acilde's imprisonment. Matos Paoli's imprisonment also facilitated his delocalization, which we have previously referred to as schizophrenia. The contrast between Acilde's and Argenis' time traveling experiences offers us a similar insight into madness than Matos Paoli's poem and psychiatric records. Similar to how Acilde's experience was prophetic within an Afro-Caribbean religious context and ultimately seen as a kind of bodily freedom, Matos Paoli sees his own madness in *Canto de la Locura*, facilitated by his imprisonment, as a kind of mystical opening and psychic freedom that drew him closer to the Catholic god. Meanwhile Argenis' narrative serves as contrast, where his chaotic existence trapped between world 1 and 2, causes him to suffer dearly to the point he needs to be hospitalized. This is a similar story depicted in Matos Paoli's psychiatric records, where we can read about the frustration and incompatibilities between Matos Paoli's social environment and the alternate realities he inhabits whenever he had an episode of madness.

The transitions between realities for Argenis are not in a form that is immediately legible to the reader. These transitions just occur mid sentence, and in between world 1 and world 2 there are still words that do not necessarily refer to either one of the worlds. The existence of these words actually destabilize the entire semantic system of both world 1 and 2 and, as a consequence, the novel as a whole. They "de-signify" adjacent words, which creates a ripple effect across the novel due to the narratological connection of all words that contribute to the plot. These words reveal the fragility of the connection between meaning and language. A transition between realities signified by a chapter transition is no less legitimate than an unannounced transition within a sentence, it is just a more recognizable/familiar form. The destabilization of meaning is an essential component in the diagnosis of madness. It is no

coincidence that in the novel, it would seem like Argenis is going mad, both by the reactions of the fictional characters that interact with him and from the way language is being used to destabilize the novel's reality for the reader. His grasp on reality becomes evidently feeble the more broken/imprecise/ambiguous the language employed to communicate his story becomes. Yet what does this say about language as a medium for communication and the derivation of meaning?

Encountering these lapses in sound semantical and sometimes even grammatical use of language should make us question the very stability of language as a medium of communication. Instead we might actually signify these lapses as madness, saving us the trouble of questioning the legitimacy of language as a conduit for logical/reasonable expression. In Matos Paoli's poem, there is a poetic instance that utilizes the ambiguity of meaning in the word ignition to potentially be interpreted as both explosion and beginning. Yet because his poem is titled the *Song of Madness*, we can also assign a certain interpretation to this ignition as referring to the moment of transition from sanity to madness, as both the beginning of a bout of madness and the explosion of the previous "sane" reality. The fact is that madness, like poetic language (a creative linguistic form), puts reality and semantics into question, thus challenging the rules, socio-political and grammatical, thought to be essential for coexistence in a given world.

Madness is transitory for Matos Paoli, it is the necessary bridge or tunnel to reach an alternate logic, perhaps one where political freedom is attainable. But his poem is the *Song of Madness*, rather than the political imagination of Puerto Rican emancipation, Matos Paoli is grappling with the liminal space between worlds that madness represents. It is the experience of that liminal transitory space which Matos Paoli is composing a song for, a space which sings to him an impossible song reveling through the potential multiplicity of reality the totality of God.

The poem itself is composed in a free verse style that jumps around distinct semantic environments. In the formatting of the poem there are empty spaces between stanzas that signify the break from the logic of the previous thread of verses. Those spaces, appearing in an unsystematic way throughout the entire poem, point towards madness through the reification of language on the page. Similar to the transitions between timelines in Indiana's novel, the way language is being used in a song of madness (or scenes of madness in the case of the novel), points at its dual nature as an accomplice in inciting madness. Language is a silent witness to the transitions and, when reading a text such as the psychiatric records, a prosecutor who identifies and makes the case to sentence the madman.

A language's grammar can trap us within a given logic, thus distancing us from the totality of potentially contradicting ontologies that madness reveals. But it can also be used metaphorically to make us realize that language itself is the product of a kind of madness that facilitates the transition from material reality to abstract, past, future or imaginary realities. We go mad when we read, each word, sentence, page, chapter, book becomes a transition into a new world, which can exist bound to a certain culture or linguistic community by virtue of a grammar. This gives the process of going mad internal consistency such that it collapses the revelatory nature of madness into a conservative concealing. Grammatical language, because of its maddening origins, still contains the potential to reveal totality but it must be intervened by altering and disrupting the cultural forms accepted by the grammar. The use of rhetorical devices and the free verse in *Canto de la locura*, disrupts language and leaves those empty spaces between stanzas as a liminal transition space between words to peer into the impossible space of madness, the locus of totality which Antonio Benítez Rojo calls the essence of the Caribbean²⁶

²⁶ Benítez Rojo (1989)

and La Marr Jurelle Bruce calls the place that is madness.²⁷ Indiana does the same in her depiction of madness, yet instead of using the empty spaces she makes the complicity of language even more evident by making the transitions, the liminal spaces, words that are devoid of a fixed meaning or grammatical/narratological localization. These are the key words which break language's silent witnessing of madness into an active role of maddening.

It is no wonder that Rita Indiana writes a song that features in her 2020 album, *Mandinga Times*, with allusions to *Don Quixote* and sampling Francisco Matos Paoli's *Canto de la locura*. In "El Flaco de La Mancha," which has an accompanying video titled "En contra del abismo," named after a verse in *Canto de la Locura*, Indiana explicitly invokes the figure of Don Quixote when she invokes el flaco de La Mancha. Already at this early stage in the introduction to the song the listener should be alert. The novel *Don Quixote*, is not only deeply tied to a history of literature portraying madness, but also to a very deep literary reflection on the act of reading and writing. El flaco de La Mancha (Don Quixote) allegedly becomes a madman after spending too much time reading stories of chivalry, to the point he takes it upon himself to be the protagonist of his own knightly epic. The scenes where Don Quixote performs his acts of madness are always characterized by the juxtaposition of the "real" world as perceived primarily by Sancho Panza, his esquire, and the "fantastic" world only Don Quixote (and the reader) experiences. This narrative structure should remind us of how we experience Argenis' "madness" in *La mucama de Omicunlé*.

In the music video for "El flaco de La Mancha," we get a cinematic depiction of this phenomenon. We are exposed to an iterative collection of scenes where different women are performing a spectrum of activities that oscillate between quotidian and bizarre. Many of the

²⁷ Bruce (2021)

scenes and accompanying performances eventually merge with one another. There is at first several instances of splits in the scenes where one of the women is in the foreground with a more serious tone and another is in the background with a strange off-putting air to their presence. Eventually connections start occurring across all the scenes, as if to reveal some hidden narrative behind these bizarre episodes. Yet there is no real resolution to the drama occurring at each scene. The visual story telling of the video reflects the lyrics of the song:

Con Yemayá de testigo
Visiones me han revelado
Lo que está al otro lado
Con ojos multiplicados vi
Que to' la' vaina' son una
En la carreta de alguna
Son el presente y pasado
Y lo que no está contado
Pa' eso soy oportuno

Like in Matos Paoli's poem, a kind of "schizophrenic" visions reveal what lies beyond, perhaps beyond reason, beyond language, or beyond reality. There is an acknowledgement that this revelation introduces a multiplicity of perspectives. The play between revelation and perspective engages with the hardcoded relationship between vision and truth in Western culture that dates back to Plato's meditations on the relationship between the different senses and reality, contemporarily theorized and critiqued by Oyèrónké Oyěwùmí.²⁸ A multiplicity of eyes invokes a multiplicity of truths or realities much like the kind Matos Paoli recognizes in the liminal space

²⁸ Oyěwùmí (1997)

between sanity and madness. Michel Foucault identifies these space between different logics in *Madness and Civilization* by recognizing madness not as a static illogical state of mind, but rather as the ability to inhabit alternate logics based on fantastic impressions as opposed to stable socially sanctioned facts.²⁹ In the next line of the lyrics, the revealed multiplicity obtains a mystic turn by saying that through this multiplicity it is revealed that all things are one. With a tradition that in Western philosophy goes all the way back to Plotinus, for whom all things emanate from the One, Indiana once again reformulates Matos Paoli's poetics by invoking this mystical oneness. In a similar way that she does in her novel, Indiana actually invokes a goddess from Santería, Yemayá, as a witness to this revelatory bout of madness. In doing so, this spiritual authority validates the transcendental and mystical dimension of this revelation through madness. Like in *La mucama de Omicunlé*, the Santería gods take the place of Matos Paoli's Catholic god. In tune with the role of indigenization from *La mucama de Omicunlé*, this is a kind of counter-symbolic move from Indiana's part which attempts to bring the realm of spiritual revelations and truth to a language, culture and religion that has its hybrid roots in the Caribbean rather than Europe.

In the last lines of the lyrics presented above, there is also a play with time which is topical in Indiana's novel, and although not necessarily salient in *Canto de la Locura*, it is woven into Matos Paoli's work through another poem "El Reloj." From these lines, it would seem like the present and the past are cut from the same cloth, and whatever is not counted, or recounted, at any point in this continuum becomes an opportune moment. We see this play out in *La mucama de Omicunlé*, where Acilde travels through a multiplicity of presents to save the future, thus reducing time to a collection of opportune moments that help him realize his mission. In the end,

²⁹ Foucault (2013)

Acilde seizes the opportunity of remaining as Giorgio with Lisa after it seems like they've gotten enough funds to develop the technology to rescue the devastated Caribbean sea-life.

In "El Reloj" a young Matos Paoli seems to grieve his past and repeatedly writes: "el reloj es un camino de Seda." The clock is a silk road that connects "las horas perdidas de todos tiempos." The clock measures time, defining the past as intervals of hours lost. Chronological time implies the loss of time, it treats time as a kind of sacrifice for the sake of a linear messianic future and thus gives a sense of mourning over the past.³⁰ In contrast, the opportune moment treats the past and future as constantly present, in a cyclical logic that gives rise to fortuitous moments depending on the alignment of events.³¹ The chronological measurement and loss of time, is done away with madness, where language, and particularly literature, is implicated. This is canonically exemplified in *Don Quixote* when the initial narrator of the story runs out of documents recounting Don Quixote's exploits and sets out to search for the rest of the story. Similar to *La mucama de Omicunlé*, there is a shift in temporal location at the opportune moment to recount what is necessary for the story to go on in a prophetic manner.

At the end of the second volume of *Don Quixote*, a scene depicts the historian who's documents chronicle Don Quixote's adventure and previously allowed the narrator of the novel to continue telling the story. The historian, Cide Hamete Benengeli, having just finished writing Don Quixote's death, hangs his pen on a wall and talks to the pen. Although ambiguous, in the next lines it would seem like the pen replies to the historian saying they are glad to have discredited the silly made-up stories of chivalry popular at the time by depicting the true story of Don Quixote.³² This scene possibly referenced in the music video for "El Flaco de La Mancha,"

³⁰ Agamben (2005)

³¹ Kerkhoff (1993)

³² Mancing (2003)

by the woman who sits by a telescope and writes by hand with a feather pen. This figure of the distant observer who narrates/dictates the the plot of the novel and the actions of the madman is imported into *La mucama de Omicunlé*. From his cell, Acilde runs the show in the past, even manipulating Argenis in his madness, so that he eventually hides a treasure in the distant past that can later be found by Giorgio in the late 20th century and fund the research that will save the sea-life in the future. This relationship between the distanced cool headed narrator and a mad character is reminiscent of the relationship between the writer and the reader. The writer writes a text which a reader can pick up at any time and inhabit by splitting their mind. But the act of writing itself can be seen as splitting the authors mind in order to create an alternate textual reality, which the reader can then later access from a comfortable distance between the passive act of reading and the maddening act of writing.

Don Quixote goes mad as a reader, and Argenis' madness is tied to the way the novel is written, which can point at either the state of mind the author had to inhabit to produce the text, or the mental effect the text will have on the reader. What about the case of *Canto de la Locura*? In "El flaco de La Mancha," Indiana mentions a "sagrada locura" that "te embriaga y te cura." This is the kind of madness that Matos Paoli is invoking in his poem, a madness that he has experienced as a poet and that he prescribes to the reader as a cure for a colonial mentality. He is writing as a reader of his own madness, which has been documented for the past 10 years by the psychiatrists who diagnosed him and treat his madness. Although it is very unlikely Matos Paoli ever had access to read his own psychiatric records, the pharmacological prescriptions and diagnosis served as a kind of proxy for the narratives written by his psychiatrists on his condition. In *Canto de la locura* Matos Paoli is drawing from both his intimate personal experiences with madness and what has been defined as his madness by psychiatrist. There is a

similar situation in the middle chapters of the second volume of *Don Quixote*, where the protagonists encounter the “apocryphal” version of their stories written by Alonso Fernández de Avellaneda. Don Quixote reads about his own adventures and the adventures to come, including his eventual disaffection towards his lady Dulcinea. He concludes that what is written in the book are all lies since he would never stop loving Dulcinea. As a response, Don Quixote makes sure he steers clear of Zaragoza where he was planning to go next in his adventure and Avellaneda predicted to discredit the apocryphal stories. Although Avellaneda’s apocryphal version of *Don Quixote* is only in Cervantes’ novel for the sake of discrediting it and ridiculing it, it still negatively defines Don Quixote’s actions.

The same could be said about the psychiatric discourse Matos Paoli is responding to through *Canto de la Locura*. The narrative Matos Paoli creates about his madness defines the narrative the psychiatrist documents concerning his diagnosis and treatment, which in turn shapes Matos Paoli’s narrative about madness as expressed in *Canto de la locura*. This dialectic shifts recursively thanks to the continuous production of narratives in the form of psychiatric records and poems. The psychiatric records are presumably meant to facilitate the treatment of madness and potentially cure it. The poems are initially thought of as creative expression, as a craft, and as aesthetic objects. But if we equate reading with a delusional madness, as portrayed by Don Quixote, and writing with a productive madness that cures the delusion of reading (as portrayed by the pen who writes Don Quixote’s adventures to ridicule and demystify stories of chivalry), then we get the lyrics Rita Indiana sings in “El Flaco de la Mancha:”

De la secreta laguna

De la sagrada locura

Metó mi jarro y me bebo

El chocolate y la espuma

A nadie le cabe duda

Que lo que yo hago es pintura

Medicina de la buena

De la que embriaga y te cura

Here madness is like a medicine, one that can get you drunk and simultaneously cure you. Language is the same. Following Cervantes, reading can get you drunk and writing can cure you, but only to produce a new text that a reader can get drunk off.

Matos Paoli's experience of madness is not that of a simple reader. Although I've argued that his disposition as a poet with a heightened sensitivity towards the relationship between words and the world predisposed him to madness, his material confinement in prison introduces a dimension that goes beyond the abstract space of language and directly impacts the site where language is generated: the body. The connection between language and the materiality of the body, specifically the brain, is not well understood. In the fields of psychiatry and psychotherapy, this connection is black-boxed and dealt with from two different perspectives that can, and for the most part should, come together. Psychotherapists believe conversational language can be used to change patient behavior, which implies some degree of material changes in the brain, while psychiatrists believe direct pharmacological or physical intervention on the body/brain will change behavior. Both perspectives have seen incredible results, with the most sustainable happening with a balance between the two approaches.

In the coming section I will deep dive into Matos Paoli's psychiatric records and see the way in which these texts are prescribing a view on his madness to later prescribe drugs and treatments that would further define his madness in normative ways. Unlike the reader of *La*

mucama de Omicunlé and *Don Quixote*, who “goes mad” alongside the novels’ characters, the reader of the psychiatric records is exposed to the language of “sanity” and can attempt to embody saneness through whatever is defined as not madness. But is this not the same kind of psychic operation at play between the two kinds of texts? This implies that the narrative of sanity being prescribed by the psychiatric records is functionally equivalent to the narratives of madness being created by Cervantes, Indiana and Matos Paoli. We will see how the fundamental difference between the psychiatric records, the poem and the novel is the form language takes in each text and therefore the flavor of affect it produces on the reader, not necessarily the ultimate psychic function. Matos Paoli reacts against his experience with psychiatry by documenting his interpretation of madness through the poetic form. Indiana, as a reader of both Cervantes and Matos Paoli (as evident from “El Flaco de La Mancha”) reformulates the narrative of madness through the novel form, and by using language depicting the process of indigenization characteristic of Caribbean speech. This last aspect in particular represents a counter-symbolic move from Matos Paoli’s narrative of madness that makes the text more accessible to a popular Caribbean audience and is thus more successful at generating the political subject (or reader) that Matos Paoli envisions through his radical proposal of emancipatory collective madness.

Ch. 3: Creative Forms vs. Prescriptive Forms

Consistency and Legibility in Diagnosing Madness from Matos Paoli's Psychiatric Records

So far I have investigated how madness is represented and described in several literary and artistic forms: poetry, fiction and song. These three mediums fall within what I call “creative forms” not just because of the obvious relationship between artistic representation and the creative process, but because the “forms” themselves (poetry, fiction, song) channel language in a way that give insight into the genesis of language, and therefore its nature. Often within scientific theories, understanding how something is synthesized is equivalent to understanding its essence. By analyzing how Matos Paoli and Rita Indiana have both written about madness through their respective “creative forms,” we’ve gotten access to how language creates alternate realities through a process of maddening, or a maddening process, of psychic displacement/dislocation. We found that this process, which exposes the fragility of grammar and discursive logic, is at the core of language’s inner workings. The characteristic displacement is preceded by a doubling of the psyche. Upon reading or writing, language pushes a specific narrative that normally stabilizes itself by enforcing an interpretation using the structure of grammar. In the case of poetry or experiments in fiction, grammar is taken to its limits or broken down, be it as actual grammatical rules concerning sentence syntax, or narratological grammar, referring to the rules reigning over storytelling. Beyond those limits, language reveals itself in its true form, as ample with ambiguity. Much of the artistry of forging objects through creative forms is knowing how to take language to its limits, reveal the richness that exists within its immanent ambiguity and come back to semantical language to represent this revelation putting it up for interpretation. Without the structure grammar provides, meaning multiplies itself with each new word instead of

reaching a stable interpretation. Creative forms play with the multiplicity of narratives in order to make the alterity implicit in ambiguity legible. They are not necessarily concerned with making legible the narrative itself. This is the case with Matos Paoli's poem, and when dealing with the transitional moments between worlds in Indiana's novel, although less obviously so because of the reliance on the grammar of narration throughout the novel.

The political power of creative forms comes from their engagement with narratological multiplicity at any given moment in reading, writing and, in genera, the creative process. There is an explicit simultaneity of potential interpretations once language is implemented in a creative form that facilitates political thinking as mentally embodying plurality. In this sense, creative forms facilitate a political maddening. I have focused my analysis thus far on creative forms, their use of language and their relationship to madness. In this chapter I am interested in discussing "prescriptive forms," as a kind of theoretical forgery, that is, as a binary opposite to creative forms, in order to further understand the conceptual nexus between language, politics and madness. Prescriptive forms rely on standardization, a rigid framework of rules or axioms that structure language consistently and reliably, to produce a degree of linguistic certainty within the framework. In general terms we can think of grammar, mathematics and the scientific method as examples of prescriptive forms. Even within the arts, there are "golden standards" taught in academic painting or sculpture (for example), which are famous for prescribing forms to the creative expression of an artist. The same goes for poetry and literature, a sonnet has a prescribed form, and to a lesser degree so does a novel! In many, if not all, cases human "linguistic" productions, where linguistic is here broadly construed to include from mathematics

to sculpture, are formed through both creative and prescriptive processes that allow them to communicate something and engage with a reader or a public.

Within the broad category of prescriptive forms I will be investigating the psychiatric record and its relationship to madness, as well as its particular use of language opposed to the poem, novel and song that I have already investigated. In the Matos Paoli family archive there are copies of the entire psychiatric records for the poet from 1951-2001, the period of his life from his imprisonment and his diagnosis of paranoid schizophrenia, which later becomes Type 1 Bipolar disorder, to his death. It is interesting to compare the language and form employed to talk about more or less the same events pertaining to Matos Paoli's madness as the poet writes about in *Canto de la locura*. In the book *Celan Studies*, Peter Szondi does a comparative analysis between the collection of poems in *Schneepart* by his friend Paul Celan and his observations of the poet during the time he presumably wrote the poems.³³ In a similar manner, I am interested in the contrast between the portrayal of madness in Matos Paoli's psychiatric records, recorded by the psychiatrist as a kind of witness, and the portrayal of his experience of madness in *Canto de la locura*. There are interesting transformations that occur between the "objective" plane represented by the distanced gaze of the psychiatric records, and the "subjective" or symbolic plane represented by the poems. In our previous analysis regarding the maddening effect of language, we have found that the "objective" and "subjective" planes, represented as texts, are functionally equivalent in terms of how they affect a reader. Formally they might differ between creative or prescriptive, but with the help of Szondi we will be able to say that these two forms are transformations of a common reality, which collapse the binary opposition between objectivity and subjectivity.

³³ Szondi (2003)

Matos Paoli describes the transition through madness between realities with different logics and truths as a transformation, similar to how a serpent molts their skin. The ignition of the moment where all truths become plausible, that bout of madness, causes one set of rules (grammar) reigning over reality to implode and be substituted by different relational rules. Szondi witnesses these kinds of transformations occurring within Celan as he experiences the world around him during their trip together to Berlin in 1967. He then compares his observations with the poem Celan writes during that time. Szondi's position as a witness and an external reader, makes it so that he must infer what is occurring within Celan based on interactions with his friend and his writing. He has no choice but to black-box the mechanisms of transformation and call them a poetic gaze towards the world. It is precisely this poetic gaze which I have previously identified as a precondition for madness, and which creatively gives form to text that allows readers to mimic that gaze and transiently embody madness through the medium of language. A prescriptive text desires lucidness and factual representation of whatever is witnessed by the writer. It prescribes an external structure, logic or grammar upon the text which is externally approved to be reliable. Both the creation of such a system and the collective approval of its reliability are highly political processes. The prescription of form does not assure objective truth. At best it will offer a degree of consistency, but often it produces illusions and even full blown myths regarding shared reality.³⁴

In this regard, psychiatric diagnoses are a good example of a linguistic prescription, which fixes an interpretative frame on a subject that is consistent (for the most part) with psychological and pharmacological theory. As is exemplified by the case of Matos Paoli, these diagnoses can be

³⁴ Even in the case of modern mathematical logic, it was discovered by the Austrian logician Kurt Gödel that no axiomatic system which includes Peano arithmetic (a very general mathematic formalism) can prove its own consistency.

quite unstable and change within someone's lifetime due to how little we truly understand about the human brain and mind. Regardless these diagnoses have the power to prescribe a normalized interpretation to that subject's reality, both personally and socially, to the degree it actually shapes shared reality in the image of the framework constructed by a set of axioms determined by mostly self-selected "experts." Hannah Arendt mentions a similar prescriptive power when talking about modern science in "The Concept of History." The basic rules in scientific practices prescribe the way the world should be engaged with: what is and what is not proper in order to produce valid factual knowledge about nature. The special character of modern science is that its prescriptive rules give nature a prescribed form. Through experiments, science acts into nature, creating rather than revealing natural laws consistent with the prescriptive system of truths. In this way prescriptive forms are deeply political due to their active role in delineating what is natural, in the case of science, and more broadly what is right, normal or just consistent, in the case of normative ethics, logic, mathematics and grammar.³⁵

Prescriptive forms delineate borders that decide what is "in" and what is "out" of a consistent symbolic order or language. They necessarily generate, and in a way define, the Other by casting them out of, in the case of language, proper communicability. The madman is conceived as an outcast, an individual foreign to the concept-state of psychic normality referred to as sanity. Madness is also conceived as an illness, and in some cases a disease. Michel Foucault narrates in *Madness and Civilization* that madness has a rich history in Europe and America, which leads up to its pathologization through the emergent field of psychiatry.³⁶ As a branch of medicine, and therefore a product of scientific innovation and standardization,

³⁵ Arendt (1961)

³⁶ Foucault (2013)

psychiatry falls well within the purview of what we have defined as prescriptive forms. Psychiatric conditions are defined by drawing borders between sanity and madness. A diagnosis of madness depends wholly on the ability to describe behavior that falls out of the norm of sanity in a language that is consistent with previous diagnosis that sustain and support that norm. A diagnosis will attempt to fit new “symptomatic” behavior into preexisting pathological categories. The psychiatrist’s job is to ascribe logic, a kind of grammar, to psychic deviance, and prescribe a medical/pharmacological solution to solve the inconsistency between the norm and the deviant.³⁷ In the special case of medicine and specifically psychiatry, a prescription goes beyond a normative discursive act. Because of its relationship to scientific advancement, it partakes in Arendt’s “action into nature.” After a diagnosis, which can be boiled down to an exercise in reading, interpreting and inferring a disease from a patient’s ailments or deviant behavior, a doctor will literally prescribe a potential solution that, with the rise of molecular medicine, has become increasingly pharmacological. This kind of prescription directly interfaces with a patient’s biology. If we think of biology itself as a kind of normative logic prescribed to the body as a text, then a pharmacological solution prescribes what a “diseased” body ought to be like, and it “correctly” formats *bios* (life) so that it conforms to biology (*bio*-logic) and is consistent with “normal” bodies.

Disease, correction and normality are all discursively constructed for the sake of consistency. But why is science, medicine and psychiatry so concerned with consistency? There seems to be an obsession with treating nature, the human body and the mind as texts that must be made legible. There is a pervasive anxiety about not being able to read a text or be read as a text. This is a problem regarding power. Illegibility exposes the limits of language, it exposes its

³⁷ The choice of terms here is crucial, in a way I am using some poetic license with my terms to understand how language works within its prescriptive mode.

fragility and makes communication impossible. It implies a kind of faith beyond the realm of linguistic interaction and therefore human interaction, which strips away human agency, self-determination and power to enact a human will.

Allow me to construct an overly simplistic mythological narrative loosely based on European history for the sake of developing this idea concerning the anxiety surrounding illegibility and its relationship to power. In this mythos I take the Middle Ages³⁸ to be traumatic for the European body politics and the enlightenment as a “therapeutic” reaction to that trauma. The process of secularization that begins with the enlightenment³⁹ is as a slow coup d’eta upon the agglomeration of power the Catholic church had amassed by profiting from citizens’ faith in the Christian god through their bureaucratic practices instead of direct engagement with religious texts. Protestantism in its Lutheran origins was concerned with precisely the illegibility of the Bible for non-Latin speakers. The translation of the sacred texts into German meant a shift in power, it meant a different political configuration for German speakers in the sense that they were then able to interact with the Bible with a new found intimacy and reconfigure resources that were being syphoned away to sustain the Catholic bureaucratic apparatus. By increasing legibility, catalyzed by a translation into the mother tongue, there was an increase in control and power over the interpretation of sacred texts for German speakers.

The overly simplified logic behind Protestantism presented above can be used to understand the process of secularization. Science became a site for the production of consistent systematic knowledge about nature, which could often contradict the Catholic interpretation of

³⁸ A category that collapses a very long and rich period of history for the sake of historical differentiation between epochs.

³⁹ This is an assumption I am making for the sake of my story. There is plenty of scholarship that problematizes the process of secularization in European history which I do not have space to discuss here.

religious scripture, and thus be seen as opposed to the exploitative aspects of Catholic faith.⁴⁰ The anxiety around illegibility boils down to a political anxiety around the instrumentalization of faith against freedom, individual and collective agency. Legible consistency works as a myth the polis can rely on to justify faith in systems and institutions predicated upon supra-human power. Yet we have seen that this myth is itself politically charged. Legible consistency and the prescriptive form of language that facilitates it have to define the borders of what is consistent and what is not consistent, determining who is a “citizen” of the polis, and who is not, who is a foreigner, and who is the Other. The definition of these borders depends as much on the definition of citizenship as of foreignness. The psychiatric record, as a prescriptive form, takes sanity as the standard for citizenship, and madness as foreignness. The particularity about psychiatry and medicine in general, is that subjects are not necessarily fixed within the social status of sanity or madness, but rather they offer prescriptions to transition from madness to sanity. Any foreign madman can become a “naturalized” immigrant in the land of sanity through psychiatric intervention.

How exactly does the prescriptive form of psychiatric language define madness, and how does it try to naturalize madness using its prescriptions? As we have mentioned, one dimension of its “prescriptions” is pharmacological: a direct interaction with a patient’s biology via chemical manipulation, which transforms the body into a kind of text and biology into its grammar. But there is a preliminary sense in which psychiatry defines madness. Before prescribing any form of therapy or drugs, a psychiatrist must evaluate a patient. From these

⁴⁰ It is again worth mentioning that the history of science in Europe is complex, and there were many cases of scientific research and discovery that were done from within the Catholic infrastructure. I am here referring to major scientific findings, like the Heliocentric model of our planetary system or the theory of evolution, which were deemed heretic due to their clash with institutionally rigid interpretations of the Bible.

evaluations, the psychiatrist can determine a diagnosis and subsequently a treatment or solution. But how is language being used during the evaluation? In order to determine a diagnosis, the evaluation must be drawn from a set of standards which facilitates the legibility of a way of being which is otherwise illegible. Today such a set of standards would be the fifth edition of the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM-5) published by the American Psychiatric Association. At this stage in the evaluation, a certain kind of language is being prescribed to produce a consistent diagnosis. Just like we analyzed how language was being deployed in Matos Paoli's poem, and Rita Indiana's novel and song to represent madness through creative forms, we now want to investigate how language is being used in Matos Paoli's psychiatric records to describe and define madness through prescriptive forms.

One of the first things that becomes evidently different between the psychiatric records and the literary texts is the constant presence of chronological time. Whether it is in the records narrating the interactions with the patient or the history of prescribed drugs, these documents are filled with dates that places patient lives within a consistent timeline. Although very basic, this act already prescribes a progressive logic to the development of a patient's condition. Having a clear chronological order of events recorded in external documentation grants madness a first degree of legibility that is not necessarily accessible by interacting with the patient "off the records." Besides the imposition of a chronological ordering, the psychiatrist consistently uses a set of narratological devices in order to diagnose and make decisions about the patient's condition. First and foremost there is repetition. The psychiatrist points out repetitive tropes in the patient's otherwise deviant behavior and uses consistent wording to describe new instances of what is interpreted as the same behavior at different progressive time points. Identifying a repetitive behavior and recording the rate of repetition can function as the basis for a diagnosis.

Once these tropes are identified, the psychiatrist must match the behavioral profile with symptoms described for a condition present in the standardized text. Doing so will potentially define the type of madness a patient is experiencing and prescribe a solution, a way to “naturalize” the patient into sanity.

The writing in the records is in 3rd person narrative form, where the psychiatrist is an impartial witness to the patient’s story who has the power to interact with the patient. The impartiality of the witness is expressed by the way in which the psychiatrist writes down patient experiences as they are told to them, with an air of objective observation. The psychiatrist is also able to contextualize patient experience by drawing from interactions with the patient’s material and social environment. This contextualization is key in generating a diagnosis. In this way the psychiatrist is able to piece together how patient behavior both affect people around them and is affected by their environment. Although the intent of the psychiatrist as portrayed by the records is that of witnessing and contextualizing patient behavior and illness, there is an obvious but unspoken curatorial practice occurring in the background. The psychiatrist will never write down everything a patient tells them. They will select the components of what patients tell them that they deem noteworthy based on their particular training, that is, the psychological grammar to which they prescribe. This is the first filter that transforms patient experience and behavior into the prescriptive form of psychiatric records. It formats madness through a disciplinary grammar that renders legible that madness that was previously illegible by the socio-political and cultural context from where psychiatric practices originate.

The general affect of the psychiatric records is of tragic factuality. There is drama between a patient’s progress and regression, taken to be objectively measured by the psychiatrist. In the case of Matos Paoli, his condition was considered to be incurable, but treatable, from early on

based on his symptoms and responses to treatments. This verdict, based on a prescriptive analysis in consultation with the set of psychiatric axioms, set up Matos Paoli for a tragic existence, at least within the scope and textual reality of his psychiatric records. This is not necessarily consistent with what the poet expresses in his creative writing. There are many cases where Matos Paoli celebrates his madness as being an eye-opening experience that revealed aspects of the world he had been blind to before. He mentions that these experiences and revelations have made him a more humble person and enriched his poetic practices. Regardless, the initial tragic verdict is continuously enforced through the prescription of treatment that “normalizes” his behavior. Progress or regression is based upon how well or bad patient response to treatment aligns with a statistically significant majority of other patient responses. Although madness is a delicate matter, which can be induced by any number of external and internal factor, as well as preconditions of someone’s livelihood, psychiatric solutions tend to simplify its rich complexities for the sake of efficient wellbeing and consistent legibility.

There is an unspoken struggle between Matos Paoli’s madness and his poetic practice within his psychiatric records. One of his psychiatrist, Arturo Flores Gallardo, writes an abstract on Matos Paoli’s life until his incarceration and subsequent diagnosis with paranoid schizophrenia. He notes the early loss of his mother as salient for the kinds of symptoms he later exhibits. The death of his mother, Susana Paoli Gayá, becomes one of the main repetitive motifs across Matos Paoli’s records. Flores Gallardo comments on a connection between Susana and the figure of the Virgin Mary whom Matos Paoli consistently presences in mystical experiences. This secularization of mystical experiences is another trope in the records. It is reported that Matos Paoli believed that his mystical experiences enhanced his poetic practice, but Flores Gallardo mentions that although this showed a degree of self-consciousness regarding his episodic

madness, leaving Matos Paoli in solitude to have his mystical experiences was detrimental to the progress of his psychic well being. Interestingly, when it came to the actual poetry Matos Paoli was producing, Flores Gallardo praises the richness of the verses. At one point in the records he quotes a series of verses from a poem titled “Salmo al Sol” as part of the report when attempting to describe the patient’s experience of madness.

En tinieblas sostuve mi ser, porque el eco de tu esplendor aún no se había fugado. Siempre permanecía en la apariencia a tu lejanía incandescente, con un poco de azul en los reflejos que, de vez en cuando, venían a visitarme.

Yo juzgaba por los presentimientos de tu nombre amado, y aún era cierta la aureola que me conducía al espacio en libertad. Aunque rezaba, dominaba el ramal de tus lirios, uno a uno, desprendidos sobre la carne enferma.⁴¹

This is an incredible moment in the records. Suddenly a creative form of language disrupts the sterility of the report used to inform the poet's prescription!

The intervention of poetry within the psychiatric record is both a failure and success for psychiatry. It is a failure because it leaves the comfort of mechanical language that it uses to prescribe its corrective drugs and therapies by referencing verses from a poem written by the patient. But it is a success because it identifies that there is something important in the poem that the language of psychiatry cannot capture. It conveys valuable information, or rather expression and affect, that is crucial for understanding the actual condition of the patient and designing a proper care response. This doesn’t necessarily happen. The next page in the dossier is the list of prescription drugs and number of electro-shock therapies Matos Paoli receives in the subsequent years, which is not much different than what he had been receiving previously. This said, with

⁴¹ Matos Paoli (1953-2000)

time, his prescriptions did change, and eventually even his diagnosis: from schizophrenia to bipolar disorder. It is likely that this was just an effect from rapidly changing practices of psychiatry in the second half of the 20th century. After all, psychiatry was a very young medical science at the time Matos Paoli was admitted into the psychiatric hospital. But we cannot ignore the potential role his poetry consistently played in defying the prescriptive language being forced onto him, to the point his poems were officially included in the reports by the psychiatrists themselves.

Conclusion

Prescriptive and creative forms are two birds of a feather. Creative forms defamiliarize language. They use it as a medium to reveal the fragility of how reality is constructed, including language itself. Prescriptive forms make language increasingly more familiar, they make it follow a set of rules to assure its internal consistency. Creative forms could not be shared and interpreted if it was not for the development of consistent rules or patterns that render content legible, and prescriptive forms would not exist if no one created its axioms in the first place. Both forms of language interact with the reader by displacing their mind. While creative forms might draw a reader's attention into a fictitious world,⁴² prescriptive forms draw a reader's attention away from any world that is not consistent with the reality defined by its axioms.⁴³ In both cases, the reader's attention is being manipulated, and their mind is being split between the realm of being in the world and the realm of language, which generates both fiction and truth. As

⁴² I am thinking in more general terms also of how the term "world making" is now used to refer to the practice of artists in any number of media, and how the public is drawn into and as part of these worlds.

⁴³ Contemporary logicians use what they call possible worlds to give meaning to modal logic in a manner analogous to my description.

previously expressed, the binary opposition created between these two terms is functionally collapsible.

Madness is the liminal condition where someone actively transitions from one possible world to another. It is a state where we have access to multiple ways of being in different worlds, without the necessity of consistency. Francisco Matos Paoli experiences this state as a mystical experience that brings him closer to God. After 18 months as a political prisoner, Matos Paoli is transferred to a psychiatric hospital where this state of mind is diagnosed as paranoid schizophrenia. 10 years after his diagnosis and throughout which he received constant treatment, Matos Paoli wrote *Canto de la Locura* reflecting on his experiences with madness. In the poem he poetically narrates the dynamic nature and affect of his madness, connecting it to both nationalist politics and Catholic religion. His claim “tenemos que enloquecer,” calls on the reader to go mad with him, instigating a revolutionary call to Puerto Ricans where madness serves as the key to freedom from colonialism.

In *La mucama de Omicunlé*, Rita Indiana portrays madness differently, both at the level of content and form. Many of the character in the novel who interact with Argenis believe he is going insane, including himself. In reality he has time traveled thanks to his accidental interaction with a powerful anemone that split his consciousness between a body in the present and a body in the past. The fictional reality Indiana constructs throughout the novel re-signifies Argenis’ madness as truly an interaction with mystical forces attempting to fulfill a prophecy. The mythology Indiana invokes belongs to Santería, an Afro-Caribbean religion practiced mainly in the mayor Antilles (Cuba, Dominican Republic and Puerto Rico). Unlike the Catholicism Matos Paoli practiced, Santería took form through a long process of indigenization of African religions and customs during the plantations era in the Caribbean. The same can be said about the

Spanish used in the novel. Unlike the erudite Spanish Matos Paoli uses in his poem, Indiana uses a colloquial Spanish that has become indigenous to the Dominican Republic through a long process of mixing the colonial language with African and Taíno words and manners of speaking.

The effect of Indiana's decision to use both religion and language that has become indigenous to the Dominican Republic is a counter-symbolic move from Matos Paoli's religious and linguistic references. According to Sylvia Wynter, a counter-symbolic move brings with it a degree of visibility for the "underground," those realities and discourses that percolate through and shape quotidian life unacknowledged by the elite.⁴⁴ The flip of symbolic discourses empowers the disenfranchised as well as the commoner who realizes how the symbolic systems of the underground currents of culture shape their life. For this reason, I hold that Indiana's way of portraying madness is more accessible to a Caribbean audience, and therefore more effective at reifying Matos Paoli's revolutionary claim than his own poem.

The reification of madness as a political revolution occurs, in part, as reading and writing text. We have already determined that madness introduces a multiplicity of ways of being-in-the-world in the psyche of a single individual. This is essentially an embodiment of the Other. Through madness, the individual can get an intimate sense of what Hannah Arendt calls plurality, which she claims is the foundation for human politics.⁴⁵ Reading text, particularly fiction, is canonically associated with madness through Miguel de Cervantes' novel *El ingenioso hidalgo don Quijote de la Mancha*, where the main character, Don Quixote, goes mad and begins impersonating a knight-errant after he reads too many stories of chivalry. Indiana connects *Don Quixote* and *Canto de la Locura* through her song "El flaco de la Mancha," and with *La mucama*

⁴⁴ Wynter (2007)

⁴⁵ Arendt (1998)

de Omicunlé by nature of being its author and their common portrayal of madness. These connections center reading and the production of text as an important access point to madness as a political instigator for freedom from Western colonial reason.

The most obvious opposition to Matos Paoli's claim of collective psychic freedom through madness is psychiatry, specifically his own psychiatric records. Unlike poetry or the novel, these records utilize a prescriptive instead of creative form of language. I have exposed how the distinction between these two forms is collapsible. That said, it is important to study how these records are constructed and how they draw from the set of standards that give shape to psychiatry (like the DSM) and generate its prescriptions. The first step constructing the record and defining the patient's madness is interpretative and curatorial at heart. The psychiatrist has to read the patient's behavior, their narratives and their context to then curate a text that records potential psychological deviances. This step is already prescribed by medical training and standard practices documented in DSM, which down the line of psychiatric consultation will define both diagnosis and the ultimate prescription of treatment. In order to make the diagnosis and evaluate the effectiveness of treatment, the psychiatrist looks for patterns in the deviant behavior and the disruption of these patterns for the sake of first, making madness legible, and then transforming it into "normal" behavior that is assumed to be generally legible to a preconceived notion of society.

The prescriptive nature of psychiatry manifests itself at both the discursive level, where the report and a diagnosis are constructed, and at the biological level, where drugs are prescribed to a patient to help regulate behavior or stabilize symptoms. This dual nature of psychiatry is an excellent example of what Sylvia Wynter refers to as the way in which we are "hybridly" human in terms of both our biology and the origin-stories we tell about ourselves, which she calls

cosmogonies or mythos.⁴⁶ As a practicing psychiatrist, Franz Fanon develops the concept of sociogeny to bridge the gap between social and biological determinants of psychological pathologies. Wynter uses this concept to develop her sociogenic principle, which attempts to engage with the question of what is human consciousness and how it work by arguing that it is irreducible to biology or the “genomic principle” because of the cultural aspects of being-in-the-world that shape consciousness.⁴⁷

Hannah Arendt also makes a similar claim to the hybrid nature of humanity when laying out her theory on the human condition in the book by the same title. She situates the human condition in between biological imperatives like food, water, shelter, and the labor needed to meet these, the artifacts produced by the work of artisans, craftsmen and other specialized workers, and the actions and narratives that we tell each other in order to live together and populate history.⁴⁸ Speech, and therefore language, has a central role in the realm of human action which defines politics. Actions are fickle, they happen in an instant, with or without leaving a trace of who or how someone acted. Speech and writing can capture action in a narrative and create a memory to be remembered later by someone else and inspire their actions. Language, specifically metaphorical language, makes another appearance in Arendt’s philosophical thinking as essential for the manifestation of thinking, a contemplative kind of activity which Arendt holds as the quintessence of being alive.⁴⁹ Poiesis (poetry) is at the heart of Bios (life), and being human is both being as an organism subject to physical, chemical,

⁴⁶ Wynter (2007)

⁴⁷ Wynter (2001)

⁴⁸ Arendt (1998)

⁴⁹ Arendt (1977)

biological and environmental changes, and as a fictional character subject to grammar, rhetorical devices, poetic licenses, literary tropes, narrative techniques and the end of a text.

In this thesis I have essentially sought to create a bridge between the the dual human condition of bios and mythos (life and narratives) and the sociogenic principle that Wynter proposes and can be read into Arendt's political theory. The lynchpin to this bridge has been the condition of madness as portrayed by Matos Paoli and Indiana in poetry and fiction. Madness is both the possibility and consequence of literature, Cervantes masterfully illustrates this claim through *Don Quixote*. The schizophrenic nature of literature, as with other creative forms of language broadly construed, goes beyond the activity of remembrance that regular speech facilitates while still using the same underlying logic. Just like a memory displaces the subject in time to embody the past, fiction displaces the subject in reality to embody what lies beyond reality, that is, what lies beyond the self: the Other.

Modern psychiatry treats this condition by using prescriptions drugs and physical interventions that target the human organism as a proxy for the symptoms expressed by both character and organism. The socio-political essence of madness and its intimate connection with language is often unacknowledged by psychiatrists due to the prescriptive nature of psychiatric treatment. There is essentially a lack of thinking that is at risk in the prescriptive form of language, that puts life in danger. The lack of metaphorical language can be taken as a sign of this lack of thinking if we follow Arendt, but I'd like to rephrase it as a constrain on creativity given a pre-fabricated grammar, that can either make thinking flourish or wither depending on how tight the constrains are. Madness is unbounded creativity, which can either free or consume the mind and the body. Psychiatry targets the body and prescribes it the mind of a character that is consistent with social norms and the dominant culture. Contemporary fields of study like

neuroscience are attempting to elucidate how it is that the organism, the body, generates the mind through biological processes in the brain, which would give psychiatry a much more nuanced understanding of the mind-body relationship and finer tools to intervene in pathological behavior and disease. But Indiana and Cervantes show us that language is also generating madness, a mental state that Matos Paoli, in his own personal experience, sees as eye-opening, revealing the means for a psychic revolution against the colonial powers still plaguing Puerto Rico today.

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Appendix:

Translations in order of appearance:

Yo quiero conocerme:

abandonar la ignota multiplicación de los astros,
la abundancia tranquila
en que el amor es loto.

I want to know myself:

to abandon the unknown multiplication of the stars,
the calm abundance
in which love is lotus.

Yo, aunque demente,

no me cojo miedo en la insolidaria alondra,
me atrapo en el diáfano estertor de la tiniebla,
me fecundo a mí mismo
al saber que soy el otro rodeado de centellas.

I, though insane,

do not fear myself in the insolent lark,
I am trapped in the diaphanous death rattle of the darkness,
I fecundate myself
knowing that I am the other surrounded by sparks.

Tenemos que enloquecer

extraer de nosotros mismos la raíz despavorida del cielo
volcar nuestras miradas fatigantes,
quedar solos con una extraña soledad acompañada

We have to go mad

to extract from ourselves the terrified root of the sky
to overturn our weary gazes,
to be alone with a strange accompanied solitude

Después de la sutil locura
se agranda mi dios en los lirios,
empiezo a darme luz en las esquinas
y se paraliza el polen de los muertos
en lo que de mí está sellado.

After the subtle madness
my god is enlarged in the lilies,
I begin to give myself light in the corners
and the pollen of the dead is paralyzed
in what is sealed in me.

me llaman.
Que hacer si los brazos ahuecados
aún repiten el aroma?

They call me.
What to do if the cupped arms
still repeat the scent?

La ignición del sueño
comienza a crecer.

The ignition of the dream
begins to grow.

Con Yemayá de testigo
Visiones me han revelado
Lo que está al otro lado
Con ojos multiplicados vi
Que to' la' vaina' son una
En la carreta de alguna
Son el presente y pasado
Y lo que no está contado
Pa' eso soy oportuno

With Yemayá as witness
Visions have revealed to me
What is on the other side
With multiplied eyes I saw
That all the pods are one
In the wagon of some
They are the present and the past
And what is not counted
That's why I'm opportune

las horas perdidas de todos tiempos.

the lost hours of all times.

De la secreta laguna
De la sagrada locura
Meto mi jarro y me bebo
El chocolate y la espuma
A nadie le cabe duda
Que lo que yo hago es pintura
Medicina de la buena
De la que embriaga y te cura

From the secret lagoon
Of the sacred madness
I put my jug in and I drink
The chocolate and the foam
No one has any doubt
That what I do is painting
Medicine of the good kind
The kind that intoxicates and cures you

En tinieblas sostuve mi ser, porque el eco de tu esplendor aún no se había fugado. Siempre permanecía en la apariencia a tu lejanía incandescente, con un poco de azul en los reflejos que, de vez en cuando, venían a visitarme.

Yo juzgaba por los presentimientos de tu nombre amado, y aún era cierta la aureola que me conducía al espacio en libertad. Aunque rezaba, dominaba el ramal de tus lirios, uno a uno, desprendidos sobre la carne enferma.

In darkness I held my being, because the echo of your splendor had not yet fled. I always remained in appearance to your incandescent remoteness, with a little blue in the reflections that, from time to time, came to visit me.

I judged by the presentiments of your beloved name, and still the halo that led me to space in freedom was certain. Although I prayed, I dominated the branch of your lilies, one by one, detached on the sick flesh.